How to mix the colour and its shades

Black from a tube is not the only possible black. Black pigments can be based, for example, on carbon or iron oxides. It can also be mixed from colours that mute each other. Each way turns out a little differently and each has its own undertone.

Not every pair of colours makes a truly deep black. Some mixtures end up brown or grey. **You will see the undertone only after lightening.** Take a little of the black mixture and add white. Suddenly a blue, brown or greenish tinge may show.

What to prepare



Ready-made black
For example carbon black or black iron oxide. Individual pigments differ.



Dark blue
For example ultramarine for a colour-mixed black.



Burnt umber
Dark brown to go with blue.



Dark green
For other deep mixtures.



Dark red
Together with green it makes a deep dark.



White
For lightening and recognising the undertone.

Colour-mixed black

You can get a dark mixture close to black by combining suitable pigments that mute each other. **One practical way is ultramarine blue with burnt umber.** A predominance of blue creates a cooler impression, a predominance of umber a warmer one.

This also explains the mystery of two black garments that suddenly "don't go together" in daylight. Black pretends to be simple. In fact it has family quarrels too.

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What the additions do



Blue

Shifts toward a cold blue-black. Add by the tip.





Umber

Shifts toward warm and softer. Too much umber makes it brown.





Green

Shifts toward green-black, woodland and deep.





Violet

Shifts toward violet-black, evening-like and mysterious.





White

Lightens to anthracite and smoky. You will see the undertone.





Ochre

Warms toward a warmer impression. Only the tip of the brush.



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Ten blacks to try

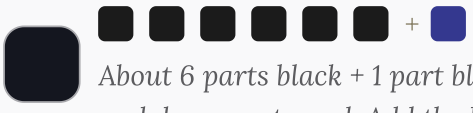
A part can be a drop, or an equally big heap of paint. The strength of pigments differs, so **take the ratios as a starting point for trying**.

Neutral dark



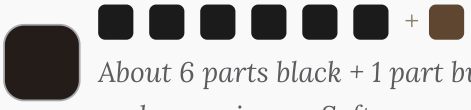
Start with roughly equal parts of ultramarine and burnt umber, then adjust the ratio. Colour-mixed, livelier than black from a tube. More blue cools it, more umber warms it.

Blue-black



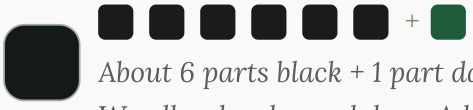
About 6 parts black + 1 part blue. Cold and deep, nocturnal. Add the blue in small pinches.

Warm black



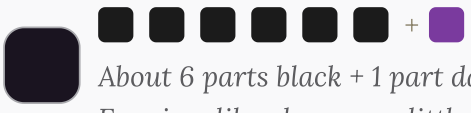
About 6 parts black + 1 part burnt umber or sienna. Soft, warm, coffee-like. Suits shadows.

Green-black



About 6 parts black + 1 part dark green. Woodland, calm and deep. Add the green carefully, it quickly takes the lead.

Violet-black



About 6 parts black + 1 part dark violet. Evening-like, dreamy, a little mysterious.

Deep from colours



Dark green and a suitable dark red, without black from a tube. Adjust the ratio according to the pigments, try in small parts. Deep and coloured, black only to the eye.

Anthracite



Black and a small amount of white, possibly a drop of blue. Firm, cool and modern. Add the white gradually.

Smoky



Black and more white, possibly a faint colour tinge. Soft and misty, on the edge of grey. Suits backgrounds and distance.

Soot



Black, a tip of umber and a trace of white. Natural, matte, recalling soot. Holds together splendidly with clay and paper.

Ink



More ultramarine and a little black. Deep as night with a hint of blue. Add the black in small portions so the blue does not vanish.

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